Baked Mac and Cheese (CUT Steakhouse)

Main dishes | Oven

Before you start

Serves 8-10. Prep about 20 minutes; total about 1 hour 10 minutes. Use a buttered 3-4-quart baking dish; bake at 375°F about 30 minutes and rest 10 minutes.

Ingredients

Matching letters and colors = one prep bowl. Charcoal = keep separate.

Bowl A - Crème fraîche and sauce salt

- [ ] 1 pound dried cavatappi pasta, or other bite-sized pasta tubes
- [ ] 6 tablespoons (3/4 stick) unsalted butter, plus extra for greasing

- [ ] 6 tablespoons all-purpose flour
- [ ] 1 bay leaf
- [ ] 4 cups milk
- [ ] 1 1/2 cups crème fraîche [Bowl A]
- [ ] 1 1/2 teaspoons sea salt, plus extra as needed [Bowl A]
- [ ] 3 3/4 cups freshly shredded mozzarella cheese
- [ ] 1 3/4 cups freshly shredded aged cheddar cheese
- [ ] Freshly ground white pepper
- [ ] 3/4 cup fresh brioche bread crumbs

1. Prepare and cook

1. Boil 1 lb cavatappi in salted water according to the package until al dente. Transfer immediately to ice water and stir 1-2 minutes until cool; drain well.

2. Preheat an oven to 375 degrees. Butter a 3- to 4-quart square baking dish. Set aside.

3. Melt 6 tbsp butter over medium heat. Whisk in 6 tbsp flour and cook 1 minute. Add 1 bay leaf and slowly whisk in 4 cups milk. Simmer, whisking occasionally, 14-16 minutes until thick. Discard bay leaf. Whisk in 1 1/2 cups crème fraîche and 1 1/2 tsp sea salt; bring to a simmer.

4. Remove from heat and melt in 1 1/4 cups mozzarella and 1 1/4 cups cheddar. Adjust salt and white pepper to taste.

5. Mix the cooked pasta and sauce; stir in another 2 cups mozzarella. Spread in the greased baking dish. Top with the remaining 1/2 cup mozzarella and 1/2 cup cheddar, then 3/4 cup brioche bread crumbs.

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6. Bake in the preheated oven until the mixture is bubbly and the bread crumbs are golden brown (about 30 minutes). Remove from the oven and leave to settle at room temperature for 10 minutes before scooping and serving.

Notes

From and tested by Wolfgang Puck, as credited in the saved file. Keep cheese portions separate: 1 1/4 cups each mozzarella and cheddar for sauce; 2 cups mozzarella mixed with pasta; remaining 1/2 cup each cheese for topping.